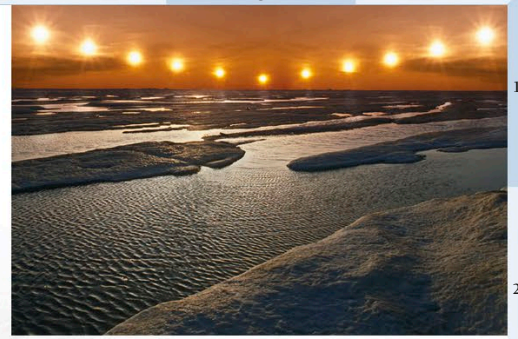




Arctic Ocean

THE SMALLEST OF THE WORLD'S oceans, the Arctic is almost entirely surrounded by the northern edges of North America, Europe, and Asia. For most of the year, its waters are covered by a thick sheet of ice, although warmer currents from the Pacific and Atlantic melt the ice along the continental coasts for a short time in summer. Despite the harsh conditions, the region is home to a range of wildlife, such as reindeer, musk ox, foxes, and wolves. Some people, including the Inuit of Canada and the Sami of northern Scandinavia, have also adapted to this tough environment.



LONG DAYS

Seasons at the poles are extreme. Polar summers are short but there can be sunshine for 24 hours a "day" as the Sun never dips below the horizon (above). This is because Earth rotates at an angle to the Sun.

ALASKAN OIL
Reserves of oil and gas in the Beaufort Sea, off the coast of Alaska, have attracted interest. However, the introduction of ships and oil platforms brings problems. In a bid to protect the area, several environmental organizations are actively working to prevent drilling for more oil in this area.

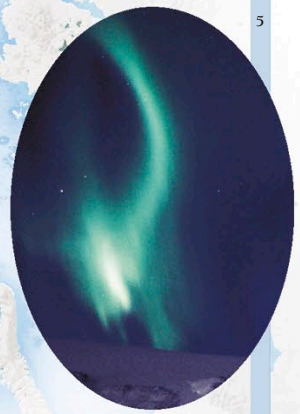
Walrus breed off the Arctic coasts.

0 km 250 500
0 miles 250 500

ARCTIC SURVIVORS

Polar bears live along the Arctic coasts of Canada, Greenland, and Russia. They hunt seals and fish at points where the sea ice melts. With so much Arctic ice having melted away in recent years, the polar bear's habitat is slowly disappearing. An insulating layer of fat, called blubber, helps the bears survive the cold. Their white fur also provides essential camouflage on the ice.

ARCTIC OCEAN



NORTHERN LIGHTS

In midwinter, the north polar skies are sometimes lit up by dramatic curtains of red and green light. Known as the northern lights, these special effects are caused by disturbances in the upper atmosphere. The same happens near Antarctica, where the effect is called the southern lights.

